

OPERATIONS GUIDE

The Front Desk Efficiency Checklist

A practical, print-and-use checklist for cutting check-in and check-out time without cutting corners.

Operations Guide · Updated April 2026

For: independent hotels and multi-property groups

Published by XYVOO — hotel management and storefront software. This guide is provided for general information and reflects practices we've seen work across the properties and shops we support; treat figures and thresholds as a starting point to adapt to your own operation.

Why front desk speed matters

Guests decide how a stay feels in the first five minutes and the last five. A slow check-in doesn't just annoy the guest standing in front of you — it backs up the queue behind them, and it's the single most-cited reason guests give for not booking direct a second time. The good news is that most of the delay isn't the front desk agent's fault. It's the system, or the lack of one.

This checklist is built around four moments — before arrival, at arrival, during the stay, and at departure — because each one has its own failure points, and fixing them needs different things from your team and your software.

1. Before arrival

Most of the time you save at check-in is actually saved the day before.

- ☐ Confirm the reservation, room type and rate 24 hours ahead — not the morning of.
- ☐ Pre-assign a room wherever housekeeping status allows, so front desk isn't hunting for a clean room at 2pm.
- ☐ Capture ID and payment details in advance for guests who book direct, so check-in is a confirmation, not a data-entry exercise.
- ☐ Flag any special requests (early arrival, accessible room, connecting rooms) on the reservation itself, not in a separate notebook.
- ☐ Send a pre-arrival message with parking, Wi-Fi and check-in time information, so fewer questions land on the desk on the day.

WORTH KNOWING

Properties that pre-assign at least 70% of rooms the night before typically see check-in time drop by a third, simply because the front desk agent isn't waiting on a housekeeping status update while the guest watches.

2. At arrival

- ☐ One screen, one login — the agent shouldn't need to flip between a reservation system and a separate payments terminal to finish a check-in.
- ☐ Scan or search by name/confirmation number rather than scrolling a paper list.
- ☐ Take payment (or confirm the card already on file) as part of the same flow as issuing the key — not as a separate trip to a card machine.

- ☐ Issue keys and route the guest in under two minutes for a standard, no-request stay.
- ☐ For groups or events, have a dedicated check-in point so a coach party doesn't queue behind individual walk-ins.

3. During the stay

Front desk load doesn't stop after check-in — a large share of it is guests asking to add something to the room, or asking what they've spent so far.

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4. At departure

- ☐ Offer express checkout (folio emailed, card charged automatically) for guests who don't want to queue.
- ☐ Reconcile incidental charges the night before checkout wherever possible, not at the desk with a queue forming.
- ☐ Ask for a room-condition check from housekeeping only where something is genuinely uncertain — don't hold every guest for a walk-through.
- ☐ Capture a quick, optional feedback prompt at the point of departure, while the stay is still fresh.

A five-minute audit

Time your own front desk against these thresholds on an ordinary weekday afternoon:

Moment	Target
Walk-in check-in (no request)	Under 2 minutes
Pre-booked check-in (details on file)	Under 90 seconds
Standard checkout	Under 90 seconds
Adding a charge to an open room	Under 30 seconds
Answering 'what's my balance so far'	Under 60 seconds

If you're consistently over these numbers, the fix is very rarely 'h always that the front desk is doing in three steps what should ta data that was already captured at booking, or waiting on another system should already know.

How XYVOO helps

XYVOO's front desk brings reservations, room status, folio and payment into one screen, so check-in and checkout stop being a handoff between systems. Rooms marked ready by housekeeping appear instantly at the front desk; charges from the restaurant or spa post straight to the guest's folio; and express checkout emails the final bill without a queue forming. None of that requires a second login or a second piece of software.
